

Intraday Trader Training Framework

A structured roadmap for beginner-to-intermediate traders, with expert notes on context, execution, validation, and risk.

Prepared March 2026 | Educational use only | This guide is a process framework, not a promise of returns.



Important: Trade only money you can afford to lose. The objective is to build a repeatable process, not to force daily profits.

How to Use This Guide

TL;DR Read once from start to finish, then reuse Modules 6 through 15 as your daily operating manual. The learning goal is process quality first, size and speed later.

This framework is designed for discretionary intraday traders who want to stop guessing and start operating from a repeatable checklist. It is intentionally structured from simple to advanced so that you can earn complexity instead of collecting random concepts.

Level	What it means	Main objective
Beginner	Learn what to see on the chart and what not to do.	Build clean pattern recognition and protect capital.
Intermediate	Add context, filters, and basic performance review.	Improve selectivity and execution quality.
Expert	Quantify, validate, and scale responsibly.	Turn a setup into a governed model, not a story.

Skill ladder

Progress by mastering one layer at a time. Complexity should be earned, not added for entertainment.

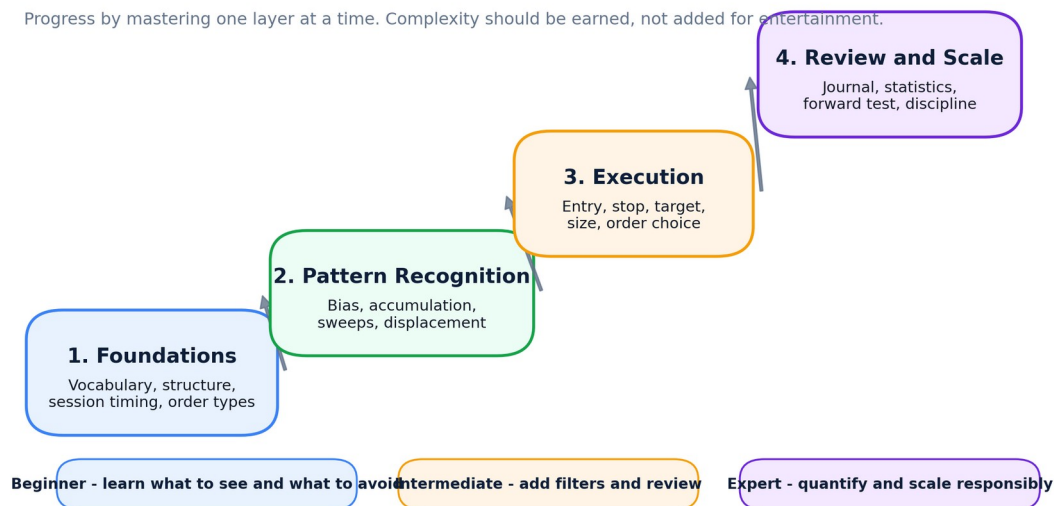


Figure 1. Skill ladder: master one layer before adding the next.

Practical reading order

- If you are brand new, focus on Modules 1 through 8 first, then skip to Module 11.
- If you already understand charts but struggle in live execution, focus on Modules 6 through 10 and Module 14.
- If you have a setup but weak consistency, focus on Modules 9, 10, 13, and 15.

Executive TL;DR

TL;DR A workable intraday process is simple: choose one liquid instrument and one time window, define higher-time-frame bias, wait for compression plus a sweep against that bias, require clean displacement, enter on a controlled retrace, define risk before entry, and review every trade in R.

1. Trade one liquid instrument until your chart feels familiar.
2. Use a higher time frame, such as 1H, to decide which side of the market you prefer.
3. Use a lower execution time frame, such as 5m, to wait for a setup instead of forcing one.
4. A common opening model is accumulation -> manipulation -> distribution, often shortened to AMD.
5. Do not chase the first impulse; wait for a logical retrace into a fair value gap or retest zone.
6. Place the stop where the idea is invalid, not where the loss feels comfortable.
7. Size the trade from the stop distance, never from maximum buying power.
8. Take profits into logical liquidity, prior highs or lows, or a pre-tested extension zone.
9. Judge yourself by expectancy and rule adherence, not by one green day.

Session map for intraday focus

The goal is not to trade every hour. The goal is to trade the hours when your setup is most likely to be clean and liquid.

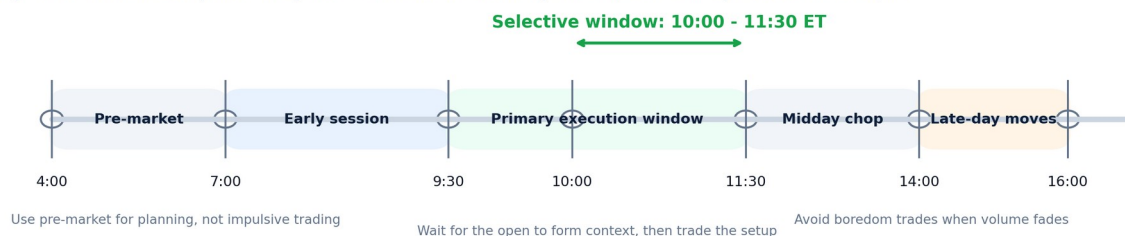


Figure 2. Time selection is a filter. Selectivity beats screen time.

Framework at a Glance

TL;DR The pattern is only one piece of the edge. The full edge is pattern + context + execution + risk + review.

Step	Question	Action
1. Define scope	What am I trading and when?	Pick one liquid instrument, one session, one execution window.
2. Set bias	Which side has cleaner context?	Use 1H structure, major levels, and scheduled news to decide long, short, or no trade.
3. Wait for compression	Is price building a range or pausing?	Mark the accumulation area and the liquidity resting above and below it.
4. Confirm the sweep	Did price run stops against my intended direction?	Require a manipulation move before looking for an entry.
5. Require displacement	Did price leave the range with intent?	Look for a strong move away from the sweep, then mark the re-entry zone.
6. Execute and manage	Is the trade still valid after size, stop, and target are defined?	Enter only after risk is known, then manage according to plan, not emotion.

No-trade conditions: Skip the setup when bias is unclear, the spread is wide, a major news release is imminent, or you have already hit your daily loss cap.

One-sentence model

Bias first. Time filter second. Sweep against bias third. Displacement fourth. Retest entry fifth. Risk defined before entry, and review after exit.

Module 1 - Market Foundations

TL;DR Trading is decision-making under uncertainty. You do not need certainty; you need a repeatable way to identify context, define invalidation, and keep losses controlled.

Beginner - what to learn first

- **Trend vs. range** Learn the difference between a market moving directionally and a market rotating inside a box.
- **Structure** Recognize higher highs and higher lows, or lower highs and lower lows.
- **Liquidity** Understand that obvious highs and lows often attract stops and attention.
- **Spread and slippage** Know that your entry and exit prices may differ from what the chart suggests.
- **Volatility** Fast markets expand both opportunity and risk at the same time.

Intermediate - what to add

- Separate structural swings from noise. Not every candle high or low matters.
- Track prior day high, prior day low, overnight range, and session open.
- Notice how volume and range change by time of day.
- Treat social media narratives as ideas to test, not facts to trust.

Expert - what to enforce

- Write objective definitions for every concept you use. If you cannot define it, you cannot test it.
- Avoid narrative anchoring. A compelling story is not an executable edge.
- Measure whether your edge comes from context, timing, execution, or simply one unusual market regime.

Mindset shift: Your job is not to predict every candle. Your job is to make asymmetric decisions where the downside is defined and the upside is pre-planned.

Module 2 - Time and Session Context

TL;DR The market open is useful because participation, volatility, and order imbalances are concentrated there. A fixed time window keeps you selective and reduces random trades.

A practical opening-window framework often waits until the first part of the open has printed some information, then narrows execution to a focused window such as 10:00 a.m. to 11:30 a.m. ET. The point is not that this window is magical. The point is that it forces discipline: you stop trying to trade every wiggle on the screen.

Beginner - what to do

- Mark your execution window on the chart before the bell or at the open.
- Use pre-market time for planning, not for emotional clicking.
- If nothing clean appears in the chosen window, your best trade may be no trade.

Intermediate - what to add

- Mark scheduled events such as CPI, PPI, NFP, FOMC, major earnings, or major company-specific news.
- Note whether the instrument is gapping into major support or resistance.
- Track whether the first 30 minutes formed a range that can later be swept.

Expert - what to watch

- Different day types behave differently: trend days, rotational days, and news shock days should not be managed identically.
- A time filter only helps if it is combined with a pattern filter and a risk filter.
- If your statistics say midday destroys your expectancy, stop negotiating with that fact.

Session map for intraday focus

The goal is not to trade every hour. The goal is to trade the hours when your setup is most likely to be clean and liquid.

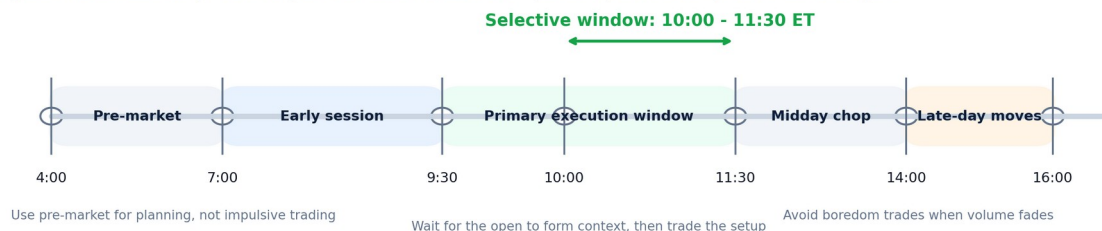


Figure 3. A fixed time window reduces boredom trades and overexposure.

Module 3 - Setup Anatomy: Accumulation, Manipulation, Distribution

TL;DR One common intraday template is simple: price compresses, sweeps one side of the range, then expands in the opposite direction. Some traders refer to this sequence as AMD.

Think of accumulation as the box, manipulation as the sweep, and distribution as the directional expansion away from the sweep. The sequence is descriptive, not magical. It helps you organize what price is doing so that you can wait for structure instead of jumping at noise.

Setup anatomy: accumulation -> manipulation -> distribution

Bullish template

Higher-time-frame bias is up, so the sweep should run down before price expands higher.



Bearish template

Higher-time-frame bias is down, so the sweep should run up before price expands lower.



Figure 4. Bullish and bearish AMD templates. Wait for the sweep before hunting the retrace.

Beginner - what to see

- A sideways range or tight pause.
- A stop run beyond the obvious high or low of that range.
- A strong move in the opposite direction that closes away from the range.

Intermediate - what to filter

- If bias is bullish, the preferred sweep usually runs down first before the move higher.
- If bias is bearish, the preferred sweep usually runs up first before the move lower.
- Heuristics such as open-low-high or open-high-low can be useful context, but they are not rules.

Expert - what to test

- Minimum number of candles inside the range.
- Minimum sweep beyond the range to count as true manipulation.
- Minimum displacement close away from the range before the retrace is tradable.

Module 4 - Bias and Context Checklist

TL;DR Bias answers one question: if a clean setup appears, which side of the market do I want to express? If you cannot answer that cleanly, you probably do not have a trade.

Context item	What to check	Why it matters
1H structure	Higher highs / lows or lower highs / lows	Keeps you trading with broader flow instead of against it by default.
Major levels	Prior day high, prior day low, overnight high / low, gap area	Targets and invalidation points often live around obvious levels.
Open location	Is price opening into support, resistance, or the middle of nowhere?	Location changes the quality of the same pattern.
News calendar	Scheduled macro or company-specific catalysts	News can invalidate normal rhythm and distort spreads.
Instrument quality	Volume, spread, and cleanliness of movement	A mediocre setup in a very liquid product often beats a pretty setup in a messy one.

Beginner - bias shortcut

- If the 1H chart is making higher highs and higher lows, prefer long setups.
- If the 1H chart is making lower highs and lower lows, prefer short setups.
- If the chart is mixed and messy, classify the day as no-bias until proven otherwise.

Intermediate - context improvement

- Notice whether the opening move already attacked a major level before your setup forms.
- Mark whether price is trading above, below, or inside the prior day range.
- Keep a small checklist beside the chart so you stop improvising.

Expert - regime thinking

- A valid pattern in poor context is still a weak trade.
- Bias should include day type, location, and catalyst regime, not only swing structure.
- If you are forcing a bias because you want a trade, the review should flag it immediately.

Module 5 - Entry, Stop, and Target

TL;DR Do not chase the displacement candle. Let the market prove direction first, then wait for a controlled retrace into a logical entry area.

Entry logic: wait for the retrace, do not chase the impulse

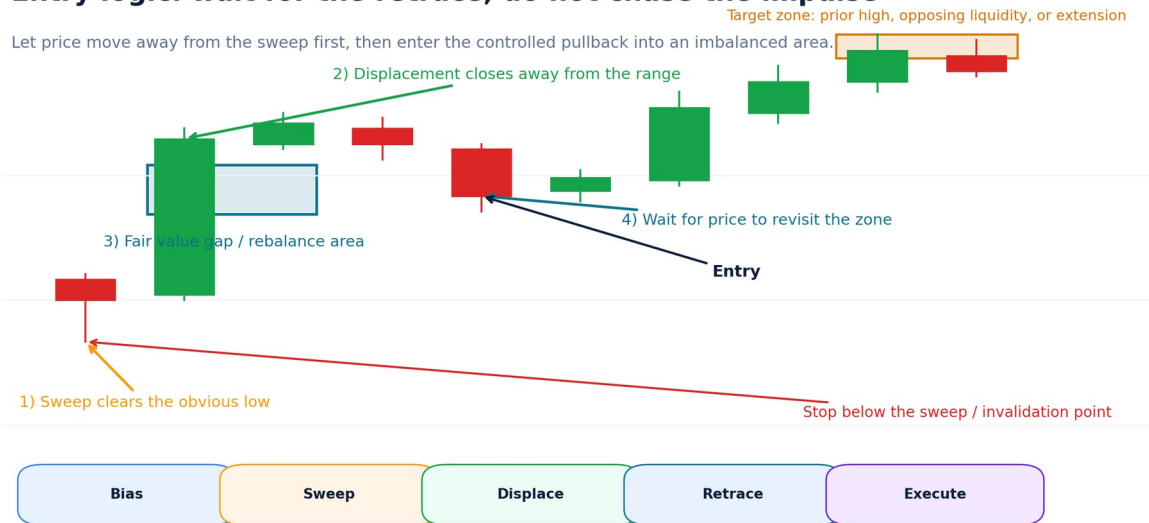


Figure 5. Example of a fair value gap retest entry after a sweep and displacement.

Beginner - basic execution model

- Wait for the sweep.
- Wait for the displacement.
- Mark the gap or retest zone.
- Enter only after the stop and target are known.
- Place the stop beyond the sweep or structural invalidation point.

Intermediate - entry refinement

- Choose between a passive limit entry and a confirmation entry. Test both separately.
- If price never retraces cleanly, skip the trade instead of chasing it.
- Target opposing liquidity, session highs or lows, or a pre-defined extension area.

Expert - optional target tools

- Some traders project extension zones with Fibonacci-based tools after the manipulation low or high and the displacement leg. Treat that as a secondary target aid, not as proof of edge.
- If the market reaches your target only after you widened the stop, the trade plan was broken even if the PnL looks green.

Module 6 - Orders and Execution Mechanics

TL;DR A good read can still produce a poor trade if your execution is sloppy. Order choice matters, especially in fast conditions.

At minimum, know the difference between market orders, limit orders, and stop orders. A market order prioritizes execution, not price. A limit order prioritizes price, not certainty of fill. A stop order activates once a stop price is reached and can be used for entry or protection, depending on the instrument and platform.

Order type	Best use	Main risk
Market	Very liquid product, urgent participation, small size	You may get a worse price than expected in fast movement.
Limit	Planned retrace entry or pre-defined target exit	You may miss the fill if price touches and leaves quickly.
Stop	Protective stop loss or breakout-style trigger	In fast markets it can fill worse once triggered.

Beginner - execution rules

- Use liquid symbols with tight spreads.
- Keep order types simple until you understand fills and slippage.
- Avoid low-float or extremely thin products while learning.

Intermediate - execution upgrades

- Use bracket orders when appropriate so the stop and target are not afterthoughts.
- Record your average slippage. A strategy that looks good before costs may fail after costs.
- Know the tick value or dollar value per point of the product you trade.

Expert - microstructure awareness

- News spreads can expand dramatically even in liquid products.
- Queue position, partial fills, and hidden liquidity matter more as size increases.
- Execution quality is part of the edge and should be measured like any other variable.

Module 7 - Risk Management, the Real Edge

TL;DR Fixed risk beats emotional risk. The trade is only valid if the stop, size, and maximum daily damage are already known before the entry.

Risk waterfall: define risk before you click

Good setups still fail. The purpose of position sizing is to make any single loss survivable.



Three non-negotiables

- Never widen the stop to avoid being wrong
- Never add to a loser unless that rule was pre-tested
- Do not size from the maximum margin the broker allows

Figure 6. Risk flows from account rules to position size, not the other way around.

Risk dollars = account size x risk percentage

Share size = risk dollars / stop distance in dollars per share

Contract size = risk dollars / (ticks to stop x tick value)

Expectancy = (win rate x average win) - (loss rate x average loss)

Beginner - minimum risk rules

- Risk very small while learning, often 0.25% to 0.50% of account size or a fixed dollar amount.
- Stop after 2R of daily losses or after three broken rules, whichever comes first.
- Never add to a loser to avoid taking the loss.

Intermediate - consistency rules

- Track losses in R, not only in dollars. This normalizes your review.
- Use the same risk unit across similar setups so your data is comparable.
- Do not raise size after one good week. Raise size only after stable rule adherence and stable stats.

Expert - capital protection rules

- Size from model quality, current liquidity, and regime stability, not from confidence.
- Do not size from the maximum leverage a broker allows. That is a constraint, not a recommendation.
- Think in risk-of-ruin terms. Large drawdowns damage both capital and decision quality.

Module 8 - Trade Management and Exits

TL;DR Entries create opportunity. Exits determine realized expectancy. Manage trades by rules, not by whether the last candle scared you.

A simple exit model is often best for developing traders: take partial profits at the first logical objective, move risk to a better place only after structure confirms, and let the remaining piece seek the larger target. Complexity is not automatically sophistication.

Beginner - simple management model

- One target is acceptable while learning if it keeps you consistent.
- If you scale out, keep the model simple, for example 50% at target one and 50% at target two.
- Do not move the stop to breakeven immediately unless your data supports it.

Intermediate - better exit logic

- Take the first partial into obvious liquidity, not into random candles.
- Trail only behind meaningful swing points, not every tiny pullback.
- Track whether moving to breakeven too early reduces your average win more than it reduces your losses.

Expert - management by regime

- Trend days often reward runners; rotational days often do not.
- A+ setups deserve cleaner management than mediocre setups.
- If your management changes daily according to mood, you do not have a management model.

Common management mistake	Better rule
Cutting winners because of a scary candle	Use structure-based exits or pre-defined targets.
Moving stop to breakeven too early	Let price earn that stop move with structure shift or target one hit.
Adding complexity without data	Test one management change at a time.

Module 9 - Backtesting and Validation

TL;DR A pattern is not an edge until it is tested with objective rules, realistic fills, and enough sample size to survive randomness.

Backtesting is where a promising chart idea becomes either a playbook or a fantasy. If you cannot state the exact entry, stop, target, time filter, and no-trade conditions, you are not backtesting - you are storytelling after the fact.

Metric	Why it matters
Sample size	A small cluster of trades can look excellent by luck alone.
Win rate	Useful only together with average win and average loss.
Average win / loss	Determines whether the setup can survive normal losing streaks.
Expectancy	Shows the average value of one trade over time.
Max drawdown	Tells you how ugly the path can get even if the model is profitable.
Consecutive losers	Prepares you psychologically for normal pain.

Beginner - how to start

- Replay one setup on one instrument and one session window.
- Log screenshots before and after each trade idea.
- At first, test rule adherence as much as profitability.

Intermediate - how to improve the test

- Include commissions, fees, and realistic slippage.
- Tag results by day type, news day vs non-news day, and trend vs range.
- Forward-test in a simulator before using live capital.

Expert - how to avoid bad research

- Separate in-sample and out-of-sample periods.
- Do not keep changing the rules until the spreadsheet looks pretty. That is curve fitting.
- A claimed win rate without rule definitions, sample size, and cost assumptions is not evidence.

Reality check: A short run of strong results can show potential, but it is not proof. Expand the sample and verify forward.

Module 10 - Journaling and Review

TL;DR Review is where the edge compounds. A trading journal is not homework; it is your operating system for pattern quality, discipline, and improvement.

Review loop: process is the compounding machine

Most traders try to improve by feeling harder. Better traders improve by reviewing cleaner.

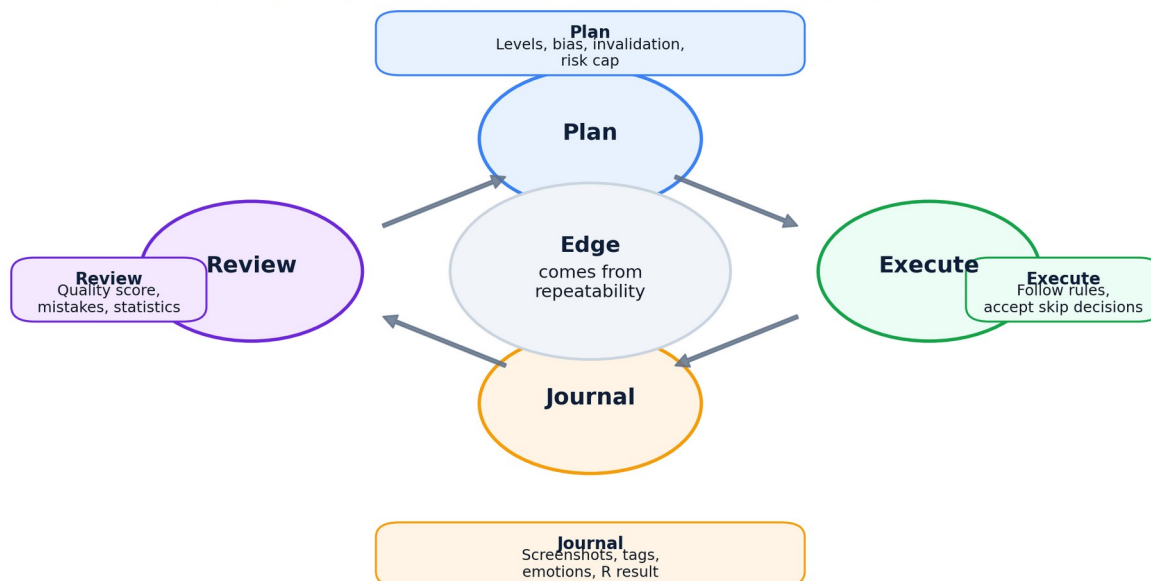


Figure 7. Improvement loop: plan, execute, journal, review, repeat.

Journal field	What to capture
Setup tag	AMD long, AMD short, continuation, reversal, etc.
Context	Bias, key levels, session window, major news status.
Execution	Entry, stop, target, order type, slippage notes.
Outcome	R result, whether the plan was followed, and why.
Behavior	Emotions, hesitation, chasing, revenge impulse, boredom.
Review grade	A, B, or C quality based on rule adherence, not on PnL.

Weekly review questions

- Which trades were rule breaks disguised as creativity?
- What hour of the session produced the cleanest setups?
- Did losses come from bad setups, bad context, or bad execution?
- What one change, if any, deserves testing next week?

Module 11 - Beginner Playbook

TL;DR Trade one simple model until it becomes boring. The beginner goal is not to be impressive. The goal is to become repeatable.

Beginner operating rules

- Trade one liquid instrument only.
- Use 1H for context and 5m for execution until that workflow feels natural.
- Mark the chosen execution window every day.
- Take only the cleanest A-setup examples.
- Risk tiny. Your first job is to survive the learning curve.
- Maximum of one or two planned attempts in the execution window.
- After the session, journal every trade and every skipped A-setup.

Daily checklist

10. Check scheduled news and major levels.
11. Set directional bias or classify as no-bias.
12. Mark the execution window on the chart.
13. Wait for accumulation. Do not pre-guess the sweep.
14. Require displacement before even thinking about entry.
15. Define entry, stop, target, and size.
16. Execute or skip. Both are valid outcomes.
17. Journal the result in R and review the chart.

Beginner trap: Do not switch instruments, time frames, and indicators every time you lose. Random variation is not proof that the framework failed.

Module 12 - Intermediate Playbook

TL;DR Intermediate progress does not come from adding ten indicators. It comes from improving context, selectivity, execution quality, and performance segmentation.

What to add next

- Track relative strength or weakness versus the broader market or sector.
- Separate continuation setups from reversal setups and test them independently.
- Refine your target logic around session highs or lows, prior day levels, and extension zones.
- Segment your results by day type, hour, and setup tag.
- Reduce trades taken out of boredom, not just trades taken out of fear.

Intermediate risk upgrades

- Keep one stable risk unit for comparable setups.
- Add a weekly stop level if your behavior degrades after a difficult day.
- Review skipped trades as seriously as executed trades. Missed A-setups teach a lot.

What not to do

- Do not widen stops to preserve a high win rate.
- Do not add new indicators unless they answer a specific research question.
- Do not increase size before the process is stable.
- Do not confuse platform skill with trading skill. Fast clicking is not an edge.

Module 13 - Expert Lens

TL;DR Experts are not prediction machines. They are selective risk managers with objective definitions, clean statistics, and the humility to pass when conditions are poor.

Expert priorities

- Regime classification: trend day, rotational day, news shock, gap-and-go, gap-fill, or no-trade day.
- Model governance: version your playbook and track what changed, when, and why.
- Expectancy decomposition: know whether the edge comes from entry quality, target placement, management, or strict no-trade filters.
- Capital allocation: scale size only after statistical stability and behavioral stability are both present.
- Risk-of-ruin awareness: large drawdowns are not only mathematical problems; they are psychological accelerants.

Expert warning signs

- You are editing rules after every loss.
- You have many chart annotations but no measurable edge.
- Your best days come from oversized trades rather than from repeatable execution.
- You keep difficult trades because of ego instead of because of a tested plan.

Expert truth: The more mature the trader, the more comfortable they become skipping mediocre setups. Frequency is not professionalism.

Module 14 - 30-Day Training Roadmap

TL;DR Train in stages: vocabulary, replay, simulation, then tiny live exposure only if the process is already stable.

Week	Primary focus	Daily work	Deliverable
Week 1	Foundations and chart reading	Study structure, session timing, bias, sweeps, displacement, and order types. Mark 20 charts.	A one-page rules sheet and 20 annotated examples.
Week 2	Replay and pattern collection	Replay historical sessions in the chosen time window and log at least 20 to 30 valid examples.	Setup library with screenshots and notes.
Week 3	Simulator execution	Execute the same model in simulation with fixed small risk and strict journaling.	10 to 20 simulated trades with full review notes.
Week 4	Forward test and process audit	Keep rules unchanged, review adherence, and only consider tiny live risk if behavior and stats are stable.	Weekly review, error log, and next-step decision.

Graduation criteria before increasing size

- At least 20 to 30 documented examples in replay or simulation.
- Rule adherence above 90 percent for the last review block.
- No repeated habit of chasing, moving stops, or revenge trading.
- A positive or stable expectancy profile after realistic costs.

Module 15 - Common Mistakes and Fixes

TL;DR Most losing behavior is repetitive. If you can name the mistake clearly, you can build a rule against it.

Mistake	Why it happens	Fix
Chasing the displacement candle	Fear of missing the move	Wait for the retrace or skip the trade.
Trading all day	Boredom and overexposure	Use one execution window and honor it.
Oversizing after a win	Overconfidence	Keep risk fixed until review justifies a change.
Moving the stop farther away	Refusal to accept invalidation	Decide the stop before entry and do not renegotiate it.
Trusting claimed results without testing	Social proof and urgency	Verify everything with your own replay, backtest, and forward test.
Skipping the journal	The loss is emotionally uncomfortable to revisit	Journal every trade while the memory is still fresh.
Adding many indicators	Confusing activity with improvement	Add only tools that answer a tested question.
Taking revenge trades	Identity tied to the last outcome	Use a daily stop and walk away when it is hit.

Pattern to remember: A setup failure is normal. A process failure is optional. Most account damage comes from process failure.

Appendix - Glossary, Source Notes, and Final Reminder

TL;DR Terms give you a common language. Rules keep that language from turning into vague intuition.

Term	Plain-language meaning
Bias	The side of the market you prefer if a clean setup appears.
Liquidity	Orders and stops clustered around obvious prices such as highs and lows.
Sweep	A move that runs beyond an obvious level before reversing or expanding the other way.
Accumulation	A tight range or compression area where energy appears to build.
Manipulation	The stop run or liquidity grab that often occurs before expansion.
Distribution / displacement	The move away from the sweep, often with strong candle closes.
Fair value gap	An imbalanced area left by a fast move that may later be revisited.
Invalidation	The point where the original trade idea is wrong.
R multiple	Profit or loss measured relative to the initial risk.
Drawdown	The decline from a prior equity peak to a later trough.
Slippage	Difference between expected and actual fill price.
Expectancy	The average value of one trade over time.

Source notes

The guide was prepared using current public educational materials on day trading, order types, exchange hours, margin rules, risk management, and trading-education safety. Verify all rules with your broker and local regulations before trading live.

NYSE Trading Hours - <https://www.nyse.com/trade/hours-calendars>

FINRA Day Trading - <https://www.finra.org/investors/investing/investment-products/stocks/day-trading>

SEC / Investor.gov Types of Orders - <https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/how-stock-markets-work/types-orders>

SEC Day Trading: Your Dollars at Risk - <https://www.sec.gov/about/reports-publications/investorpubsdaytipshtm>

Investor.gov Margin Rules for Day Trading - <https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/general-resources/news-alerts/alerts-bulletins/investor-bulletins/margin>

CFTC Learn to Trade Futures and Options Without Getting Scammed - https://www.cftc.gov/LearnAndProtect/AdvisoriesAndArticles/learn_to_trade_without_scam.htm

CME Position and Risk Management - <https://www.cmegroup.com/education/courses/things-to-know-before-trading-cme-futures/position-and-risk-management>

Final reminder: This framework is meant to teach structure, discipline, and review. It should never replace independent testing, appropriate risk controls, or professional advice where needed.